

Severin Rapp

Curriculum Vitae

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Gender: male (he/him)

Nationality: AUT/CHE

Education

- 2024 **PhD in Economics and Social Sciences**, *Vienna University of Economics and Business (WU)*, Vienna, Thesis: Perspectives on the distribution of wealth: concepts, data and perceptions, Distinction
Supervisors: Prof. Wilfried Altzinger (WU), Prof. Jesus Crespo-Cuaresma (WU), Prof. Max Kasy (Oxford)
- 2023 **Visiting Research Student**, *London School of Economics and Political Science*, London
Advisor: Prof. Francisco Ferreira
- 2018–2019 **MSc in Comparative Social Policy**, *University of Oxford*, Oxford, Distinction
Supervisor: Prof. Brian Nolan
- 2014–2017 **BSc in Economics, Business and Social Sciences**, *WU*, Vienna, *GPA 1.16, Ranked among the top 1% of the students in the same cohort*
Economics Track
- 2016 **Erasmus Exchange Semester**, *University of Edinburgh*, Edinburgh

Research interests

- Distribution
- Welfare, Well-Being, and Poverty
- Finance
- Public Economics

Research Papers

- JMP *Life Insurance and Death Benefits: What Shapes Participation, and Does It Matter for Inequality?* joint with F. Disslbacher

Life insurances pay death benefits. We study how death benefits supplement bequests, why decedents take out insurance and how tax incentives shape this decision. In a novel administrative data set on wealth at death from Vienna, Austria, we link death benefits to terminal wealth and sociodemographics and study responses to an income tax reform that changed the tax treatment of insurance premia. Several novel facts emerge. First, death benefits primarily supplement small- to mid-size estates and reduce inequality of bequests. Second, most payouts are final-expense policies that insure funerals; other benefits are tied to the presence of survivors, are hump-shaped over decedents' age, and contribute little to terminal wealth. Third, take-up of final-expense insurance responds to tax incentives, while other life insurance and net wealth at death do not. Our results shed new light on the motives to take out life insurance, the distributional importance of benefits and the tax treatment of insurance.

- Working paper *The Good Council: Deliberating inequality in a field experiment* joint with F. Disslbacher, M. Haselmayer, L. Lehner, and F. Windisch

This paper investigates how participation in a citizens' assembly affects individuals' redistributive preferences and (perceived) role in democracy. We implement a pre-registered field experiment embedded in a real-world citizens' assembly on wealth inequality in Austria. Using a three group design comparing assembly participants, non-selected volunteers, and a representative population sample, we isolate the causal effects of taking part in a citizens' assembly from self-selection into participation. We find that while participating in the citizens' assembly substantially improves factual knowledge about the wealth distribution and promotes convergence around specific tax policy proposals, notably a €1 million allowance, it has no measurable effect on political efficacy or broader civic engagement. We also document significant political self-selection: individuals willing to participate in the citizens' assembly were already more engaged and supportive of redistribution than the general population. These findings suggest that while deliberative formats can foster informed convergence on policy proposals, their ability to mobilize broader publics is limited – especially if they primarily engage the already supportive and, as in this case, lack institutional anchoring that might facilitate spillover into more institutionalized political arenas.

- Working paper *Do biased perceptions of wealth distribution affect savings behavior?*, joint with P. Fessler, Available at: <https://www.oenb.at/dam/jcr:c442f243-a839-4fd7-bc85-1d7c1b82e398/wp-249.pdf>

We estimate the relationship between people's biased perceptions of their rank in the wealth distribution and savings behavior. Using survey data from Austria, we show that there is a relationship between misperceptions and savings that is statistically significant at least at the 5% level. A one-decile downward deviation in perceived rank, relative to one's decile based on observed wealth, is associated with a 5% increase in the savings rate evaluated at the mean (predictive estimate). When using an instrumental variables approach, the estimated effect increases substantially to 18%. Preferences that feature relative wealth in the utility function can explain this relationship. Our findings inform contemporary macroeconomic models and have important implications for policy.

- Working paper *Leaving legacies and liabilities: The distribution of wealth at death*, joint with F. Disslbacher, Available at: https://wid.world/www-site/uploads/2024/10/WorldInequalityLab_WP2024_20_Leaving-Legacies-and-Liabilities_The-Distribution-of-Wealth-at-Death_Final.pdf

This paper leverages novel administrative data on terminal wealth in Vienna to show that Gini indices of wealth inequality at death exceed unity, with 20-30% of decedents leaving behind debt. We analyze the drivers of this distribution, finding that the drivers of terminal wealth (distribution) are different from determinants of wealth (inequality) among the living. Life-cycle effects have limited explanatory power. In contrast, bequest motives are associated with higher wealth and a marginal increase in the share of decedents that reveal preferences on post-mortem resource allocations reduces inequality. Homeownership also correlates with higher wealth (the reverse is true for care-home residency), though housing wealth does not benefit the bottom of the distribution across districts. Finally, means-tested long-term care transfers significantly amplify terminal wealth inequality.

Peer reviewed publications

- 2025 **S. Rapp.** *Economies of Scale for Household Wealth: An Analysis of Equivalence Scales.* Review of Income and Wealth, 71(1), 176–186, <https://onlinelibrary.wiley.com/doi/pdf/10.1111/roiw.70002>
- 2023 **S. Humer and S. Rapp.** *Wealth and Welfare: Do Private and Public Safety Nets Compensate for Asset Poverty?.* Social Inclusion, 11(1), 176–186, <https://doi.org/10.17645/si.v11i1.5937>

Book Chapters, Research Reports And Other Publications

- 2025 **S. Rapp and O. Thevenon.** *Parenting on a budget: The cost of raising children in changing family configurations and its policy implications*. OECD Papers on Well-being and Inequalities No. 36
- 2023 **S. Rapp.** *Reichtum, Natur und Wilder Westen: Farrell, Justin (2020). Billionaire Wilderness. The Ultra-Wealthy and the Remaking of the American West*. *Wirtschaft und Gesellschaft*, 49(3), 129–133, <https://doi.org/10.59288/wug493.212>
- 2023 **K. Heitzmann and S. Rapp.** *Armut, soziale Ausgrenzung und Wohnen* [Poverty, social exclusion and housing]. In: A. Buxbaum, U. Filipič, S. Pirklbauer, N. Soukup, N. Wagner (Eds.), *Soziale Lage und Sozialpolitik in Österreich 2023: Entwicklungen und Perspektiven*. ÖGB Verlag
- 2021 **S. Rapp.** *Asset bias in equivalence scale measurement*. WU INEQ Working Paper Series No. 22
- 2020 **C. Dabrowski, R. Lasser, V. Lechinger and S. Rapp.** *Vermögen in Wien - Ungleichheit und öffentliches Eigentum* [Wealth in Vienna - Inequality and Public Ownership]. Vienna: City of Vienna Municipal Department 23
- 2020 **S. Humer and S. Rapp.** *Kosten von Kindern Erhebungsmethoden und Bandbreiten* [Measuring the Cost of Children: Methods and Bandwidths]. Vienna: City of Vienna Municipal Department 40
- 2018 **S. Humer and S. Rapp.** *Entwicklung und Verteilung von Lebenshaltungskosten* [Development and distributional impact of inflation]. Vienna: Federal Ministry for Work, Social Affairs, Health and Consumer Protection

Awards, Grants and Scholarships

Total monetary value: total: approx. €170,500.00

- 2025 Kaiserschild Stiftung research grant
- 2024 Research Grant Austrian Chamber of Labour for the study of wealth inequality in Austria
- 2024 OECD consultancy contract
- 2023 WU International Research Fellow for LSE Visiting Student
- 2023 Research grant, City of Vienna Municipality Department No. 23
- 2023 Klaus Liebscher Economic Research Fellowship of the Austrian National Bank (OeNB)
- 2022 WU Foundation project grant
- 2022 WU Open Access Publication Fund awarded for Creative Commons publication
- 2022 Scholarship of Teaching and Learning, for "Fostering international knowledge transfer in higher education: Oxford Tutorial meets WU"
- 2021 Eudard März Award for best conference contribution at the 2021 Young Economists Conference in Linz
- 2019 Research grant, City of Vienna Municipality Department No. 23
- 2019 George Smith Award for best MSc-Thesis of the Department of Social Policy and Intervention, University of Oxford
- 2018 Maria Szecsi MSc-Scholarship of the Austrian Chamber of Labour
- 2017, 2016 Academic Achievement Scholarship, 2x
- 2015, 2016 WU Rector's List Winter and Summer Term, 2x
- 2015 Academic Achievement Scholarship
- 2014 Member of the WU Top League

Conference Presentations, Poster Sessions, Invited Talks

2025

- 30. EEA Annual Congress
- 29. ECINEQ Annual Meeting
- 28. Lofoten International Forum on Inequality and Taxation
- 27. Population Association of America Annual Meeting
- 26. III/LIS Comparative Economic Inequality Conference
- 25. Eastern Economic Association Annual Conference

2024

- 24. WU Vienna - LSE-WU-ZEW Workshop on Workshop on Wealth Inequality
- 24. Bocconi - ExPov Poverty and Policy Working Group
- 23. OECD ECO - Brownbag Seminar
- 22. European Central Bank - HFCN Seminar

2023

- 21. WU Wien - Austrian Economic Association Winter Workshop
- 20. University of Warsaw - 21st Annual ESPAnet conference
- 19. Aix-Marseille Université - 10th ECINEQ Meeting
- 18. Renner Institut: "Soziale Lage und Sozialpolitik in Österreich 2023. Entwicklungen und Perspektiven"
- 17. Austrian National Bank Workshop "The Measurement of Augmented Wealth: Concepts, Methods and Results"
- 16. LSE - Inaugural III/LIS Comparative Economic Inequality Conference
- 15. Politecnico Milano - Winter School "Researching Social Insecurity in Europe: measures, drivers, policies"

2022

- 14. Bocconi - ExPov Poverty and Policy Working Group
- 13. WU Wien - Workshop "Wealth Inequality and Intergenerational Mobility"
- 12. Momentum Congress
- 11. Chamber of Labour - Young Economists Conference
- 10. Swansea University - Social Policy Association Annual Conference
- 9. CUNY Stone Center Wealth Seminar Series

2021

- 8. Austrian National Bank HFCS Seminar Series
- 7. Online - Social Policy Association Annual Conference

2020 and prior

- 6. Chamber of Labour - Young Economists Conference
- 5. Online - ESPAnet Annual Conference
- 4. WU Wien - Austrian Economic Association Annual Meeting
- 3. University of Verona - ECINEQ Winter School on Inequality and Social Welfare Theory
- 2. Momentum Congress
- 1. WU Wien - Austrian Economic Association Winter Workshop

Teaching

- 2022–2024 Supervision of several bachelor theses on wealth inequality and bequests
- 2020–2024 Economic and Fiscal Policy, WU, undergraduate level, focus on social insurance, labour markets, inequality, and COVID-19

Employment biography

- 2024–2026 **Postdoctoral Scholar**, *Stone Center on Socio-Economic Inequality*, The Graduate Center at City University New York (CUNY), New York City
- 2024 **Economist**, *OECD, Centre for Wellbeing, Inclusion, Sustainability and Equal Opportunity*, Paris
- 2019–2023 **Research and Teaching Associate**, *Department of Economics*, WU, Vienna

- 2020 **Principal Investigator**, *Research Institute Economics of Inequality (WU INEQ)*, Vienna
- 2019 **Research Assistant**, *WU INEQ*, Vienna
- 2018 **Internship**, *European Parliament*, Brussels
- 2017-2018 **Research Assistant**, *WU INEQ*, Vienna
- 2017 **Internship**, *Oesterreichische Nationalbank - BAREV*, Vienna
- 2017 **Research Internship**, *Marie Jahoda - Otto Bauer Institut*, Linz

Professional activities

- Reviewer Research in Social Stratification and Mobility, *Empirica Journal of European Economics*, *Wirtschaft und Gesellschaft*, *International Journal of Pluralism and Economics Education*, *OEAD* (Austrian Agency for Education and Internationalisation)
- Member European Economic Association
- Member Institutional Review Board for Research Ethics at WU Vienna, 2021–2023

Policy

- 2021–2023 **Student representative for doctoral students**, *WU*, Vienna
- 2018–2019 **Research Policy Officer**, *European Student Think Tank*, Brussels
- 2017–2018 **Member of Education Policy Committee and Commissioner for Quality Assurance**, *Austrian National Union of Students federal body of Representatives (ÖH)*, Vienna

Other Information

- Software R, Stan, EViews, STATA, $\text{\LaTeX}$, Markdown, Git
- Skills
- Languages German (mother tongue), English (C2), French (B2), Spanish (basic)